

Clear Communication + Presence

10-Week Leadership Development Program

Daily Habit	Weekly Deliverable	Reading
Before any important conversation or email, write your single core message in 15 words or fewer. Say it first.	Record yourself speaking for 2 minutes on a work topic. Play it back. Identify one habit to change.	Synergy and Sparks: The Secrets of Extraordinary Groups — Storytelling and Clarity chapters + The 7 Habits, Habit 5 continued

Core Concept

Most leaders communicate too much, too vaguely, or too late. Research on executive communication consistently shows that the biggest problem is not insufficient information — it's insufficient clarity about what actually matters.

Effective communication starts with a single clear message. Before speaking or writing, ask: if the other person remembers only one thing from this conversation, what should it be? State that first. Everything else is context and support.

Presence — the quality of being fully there — is equally critical. Leaders who are physically present but mentally elsewhere (checking phones, planning their next meeting) signal to people that they don't matter. Presence is a form of respect, and its absence is one of the most common leadership derailers.

""The most powerful person in the room is often the one who speaks last and most clearly.""

— Leadership research principle

Framework: The 15-Second Rule

Before any important communication, complete this sentence:

'The one thing I need this person to understand/do/feel is: _____'

This becomes your opening statement. Not your third paragraph. Not after three minutes of context. First.

Storytelling structure: Setup (what was the situation) → Tension (what was the problem or conflict) → Resolution (what happened or what you learned). Facts listed in bullet points are forgotten. Stories are

remembered.

Daily Practice

- The core message drill: Before every meeting, write: 'My one message today is...' State it in the first 60 seconds.
- Recording practice: Once this week, record a 2-minute explanation of something work-related. Watch it back. What do you notice about pace, filler words, eye contact, energy?
- Story practice: Replace one set of bullet points in a presentation or update with a brief story (setup, tension, resolution).
- Presence check: At the start of each meeting or 1:1, put your phone face down. Take one breath. Be physically and mentally here.

Leadership Scenarios

Scenario 1

Your VP asks you in the elevator: 'So, how is the new initiative going?' You have 45 seconds.

Reflection: What is your one clear message? Practice saying it without any 'um,' hedging, or three-sentence preamble.

Scenario 2

You need to tell your team that a project they've worked on for three months is being deprioritized.

Reflection: How do you open? What is your one core message? How do you use story structure to make it land?

Weekly Reflection Prompts

Set aside 20 minutes at the end of this week to write your responses. These are for you — be honest.

Reflection 1: When do you tend to over-communicate (too much detail, too many caveats)? What drives that tendency?

Reflection:

Reflection 2: Think of the clearest communicator you know. What specifically do they do that makes them clear?

Reflection:

Reflection 3: Where in your communication do you bury the lead? What would it look like to lead with your core message?

Reflection:

Weekly Habit Tracker

Day	Done?	Notes / Observations
Monday	■	
Tuesday	■	
Wednesday	■	
Thursday	■	
Friday	■	
Saturday	■	
Sunday	■	

End-of-Week Summary

Reflection: What was my biggest leadership learning this week?

Reflection: What will I carry forward into next week?

Reflection: One relationship I invested in this week: